

Volunteer Notes for the Coldharbour Community Orchard

The Coldharbour Community Orchard is two and a half acres of old apple, pear and plum trees on the slope behind the primary school, planted before the war and abandoned for most of the years since. It has been looked after by volunteers since the parish bought the field in 2003. These notes are for anyone who joins a work party, takes a turn on the pressing days or simply wants to know why the orchard is run the way it is, and they assume no knowledge of fruit trees at all.

The orchard survived because nobody found a use for the field. The slope is too steep for a building and too wet at the bottom for a paddock, and by the time the parish bought it the trees had become a habitat that the county would not let anyone clear. That accident is the reason there are forty-one trees of twenty-six varieties, several of them not known to grow anywhere else in the district, and it is the reason the first rule of the orchard is that nothing is felled without a vote.

Work parties meet on the second Saturday of the month at ten, in every month but August, and finish by one. Tools come from the shed and go back to the shed; nobody brings their own saw. The shed key is held by three named volunteers, and the list of who they are is on the noticeboard by the gate and on the website. Children are welcome at work parties with an adult, and the adult is responsible for them, not the work party leader, however experienced the leader may be.

Every tree has a number on an aluminium tag at chest height on the north side of the trunk, and the number is the only name a tree has in the records. Varieties are recorded against numbers, not the other way round, because several trees were misidentified for years and a record keyed on the wrong variety would have carried the mistake into every note made about the tree. When a tag is lost it is replaced with the same number, and the replacement is noted in the book.

The map on the inside of the shed door shows every tree, its number and its variety, and the year it was last pruned. It is redrawn every five years by whoever has the neatest hand and photographed after each redrawing, so that the sequence of maps is itself a record of what was planted, what died and what was moved. The photographs live in the orchard folder on the parish computer and nowhere else.

Grass under the trees is cut twice a year, in late June after the orchards have set seed and again in September before the fruit comes down, and it is raked off and composted at the top of the field rather than left to lie. Everywhere else the grass is left long. A volunteer who wants to mow more often is asked to read the management plan first, which explains why the long grass matters more than tidiness does, and has so far persuaded everyone who read it.

The orchard has no water supply, no electricity and no toilet, and the nearest of each is at the school, which lets volunteers use them during work parties by long-standing arrangement. The arrangement depends on the gate between the two being closed behind every person who uses it, without exception, on every occasion, and on the one occasion it was not the arrangement very nearly ended.

Pruning is done between December and February on the apples and pears and in July on the plums, and never the other way round. The rule exists because silver leaf disease enters plum trees

through winter cuts, and the orchard lost three old plums to it before anyone knew why. A volunteer who is unsure which tree is which asks before cutting, and a tree with no legible tag is not pruned at all until the tag is replaced.

The aim of pruning here is to keep old trees alive and cropping, not to make them look like the pictures in the book. Dead, diseased and crossing wood comes out first, then enough of the rest to let light and air into the middle of the crown, and then the saw is put down. Taking more than a quarter of a tree's growth in one winter is the commonest way to lose it, and the second commonest is taking nothing for ten years and then a half in one afternoon.

Cuts are made just outside the collar, never flush with the trunk and never leaving a stub, and nothing is painted over them; wound paint was given up in 2011 after the county officer showed us the rot behind it. Large limbs come off in three cuts so that the weight does not tear the bark down the trunk, and anything over a wrist's thickness is left to the two volunteers who have done the chainsaw course.

Ladders are three-legged orchard ladders and nothing else, footed by a second person whenever anyone is above the third rung, and never used on the wet side of the slope after rain. A volunteer who owns a stepladder is thanked and asked to leave it at home. Most of the work can be done from the ground with a pole saw, and most of the accidents in the accident book happened to people who thought otherwise.

New trees are planted in November, on the rootstock the plan specifies for the position, and always as replacements for trees that have died rather than as additions. The plan allows for forty-one trees and the field will not carry more without the crowns closing. Each new tree is staked, guarded against the rabbits, mulched with its own leaf litter, and watered by hand for its first two summers from cans filled at the school.

Grafting is taught at the March work party by whoever learned it the year before, using scion wood cut in January and kept in the shed fridge. Every variety in the orchard is grafted onto a spare rootstock at least once every ten years, so that a tree that dies can be replaced by its own variety and not by the nearest thing the nursery has. The spare trees grow on in the nursery bed at the top of the field.

Prunings are stacked at the field edge for the wildlife rather than burned, except for anything cut out for canker or silver leaf, which is bagged and taken off site the same day. The stacks are rebuilt every few years and are not to be tidied away by a volunteer who finds them untidy; the plan explains what lives in them and why that matters.

Tools are cleaned and oiled at the end of every work party before they go back on the shed wall, and the person who used a tool is the person who cleans it. Blades are sharpened by the two volunteers who know how, on the first work party of the year, and a saw that has been used on a diseased tree is wiped with the spirit in the blue bottle before it touches another. A blunt or dirty tool is the commonest cause of a torn cut, and a torn cut is the commonest way disease gets into an old tree.

The harvest runs from the first week of September to the end of October, variety by variety, in the order on the chart in the shed. Fruit is picked when it parts from the spur with a lift and a twist, not when it looks ripe, and fruit that has to be pulled is left another week. Windfalls are gathered separately and go to the press, never into the store, because one bruised apple will spoil a tray in a fortnight.

Picking is done into padded buckets and tipped gently into the wooden trays in the shed, one variety to a tray and the tray labelled with the tree number and the date. Fruit for storing is laid in a single layer, not touching, and checked weekly; anything soft is taken out and pressed. The store is the north end of the shed, which stays cool, and it is kept dark because light ripens what it touches.

Pressing days are the two Saturdays in October and are the busiest days of the year. The press, the scatter and the buckets are scrubbed the evening before and again at the end of the day, and the juice is bottled within two hours of pressing and put straight into the cold boxes. Anyone handling fruit or juice washes their hands at the school first and wears the apron, and nobody with a cold or a cut hand presses at all.

Juice is sold at the gate on pressing days and at the village market in November, unpasteurised, labelled with the date and the words that the environmental health officer gave us, and sold within the day or given to the school. Nothing is kept for sale after the day it was pressed. The price is set each year to cover the bottles and the cleaning materials and to put something towards the tree budget, and not a penny more.

The cider group is a separate concern with its own members and its own barrels, and it buys windfalls from the orchard at a price agreed each September. It does not use the orchard's press, its members do not have shed keys, and the two are kept apart in the accounts on the parish's instruction. A volunteer asked about cider at the gate says that the group exists and that the orchard does not make any.

Visitors are welcome to pick and eat fruit on the day but not to fill bags, and the difference is explained kindly and firmly by whoever is nearest. Trees marked with a red ribbon are being left for the winter thrushes and are not picked at all. The old perry pear by the gate is not for eating and the sign on it says so, in three languages, after one memorable afternoon.

Records of the harvest are kept per tree: the date, the number of trays, the rough weight and a word on quality. They go in the orchard book in the shed on the day and are typed up in the winter. Twenty years of those figures are what told us which trees were failing long before they looked it, and they are the most useful thing the orchard owns, the trees themselves excepted.

Fruit that is neither stored nor pressed goes to the food bank in the town on the Monday after picking, boxed by variety with a note of what each is good for, because a box of unnamed cooking apples goes uneaten and a box labelled for crumble does not. The food bank's van collects from the school gate at nine. A volunteer who cannot make the box up on the Sunday evening says so on the Saturday, so that somebody else can do it instead.

Apple Day in October is the orchard's public day and the day most new volunteers first arrive. The field is open from eleven to four, the press runs all day, the school lends its hall for the identification table, and the fire brigade parks an engine by the gate because the children like it and because the field has no water. The day is planned in September and the plan is on the noticeboard by the first of October.

The identification table is staffed by the two volunteers who know the varieties best and by anyone else willing to fetch reference books. Visitors bring fruit from their own gardens to be named, and the rule is that a variety is named only when three characters agree with the reference and otherwise the visitor is told what it is not. A confident wrong name follows a tree for a generation.

Money taken on Apple Day goes into the tin on the table, is counted by two people at four o'clock, and is banked by the treasurer on Monday. The float is twenty pounds in coin. Nobody sells anything on the orchard's behalf that has not been agreed at the September meeting, and nobody takes cash home overnight, however small the sum and however late the hour, and however far from the bank they live.

Safety at every event and work party is the leader's responsibility, and the leader is whoever is named on the noticeboard for that day. The first-aid kit and the accident book live in the shed, the kit is checked monthly, and every incident goes in the book the same day with what happened and what was done. The parish reads the book quarterly and asks about anything it does not understand.

Dogs are welcome on a lead and unwelcome off one, because of the sheep in the next field and the ground-nesting birds in the long grass. Bicycles stay at the gate. Fires are not lit anywhere on the field, at any time, for any reason, and the one exception in the orchard's history was a wassail in 2014 that nobody involved wishes to repeat.

The parish owns the field and the orchard reports to it twice a year, in writing, in April and October: what was done, what was spent, what was sold, what died and what is planned. The report is one side of paper. The parish has never refused a request that came with a reason and has refused several that came without one, and the volunteers who write the report keep that in mind.

Complaints from neighbours are rare and are about noise on Apple Day or cars on the lane. They are answered by the chair, in person if possible, within the week, and the answer is written in the orchard book. The lane is narrow and the neighbours are right about the cars, which is why the September plan always includes the field gate for parking and two volunteers to wave people into it.

New volunteers are asked to come to three work parties before they are given anything to do alone, and they are paired with somebody who has been coming for years, not because the work is difficult but because most of what matters here is habit rather than instruction: which tree not to prune, which gate to close, which visitor to steer gently away from the perry pear. After the third party they are added to the list, given the notes, and asked what they would like to learn; most say grafting, and most are surprised to be taught it the following March.

Winter is when the orchard is quietest and the records are put in order. The harvest figures are typed up, the map is checked against the trees, the tags are read and any missing ones replaced, and the plan is reread by the committee before the pruning starts. Anything that needs a vote is put to the January meeting, and the minutes of that meeting go in the folder with everything else.

The nursery bed is weeded and mulched in December, and the grafted trees are counted and labelled against the variety list so that a replacement can be found in a hurry when a tree comes down in a gale. Two of every variety is the target and one is the minimum. A variety with no spare is grafted first the following March, whatever else is planned, because a variety that exists in one tree is a variety one storm away from being lost.

Lastly, these notes are revised every February by the committee and each version is dated and kept in the orchard folder. Most of the rules were paid for by a lost tree, a spoiled store or a visit from an officer, and the notes are shorter than that list, which is kept too.